Proposals

DANIEL ZAWACKI

The Art of Proposing

IDENTIFYING A PROBLEM[S] AND OFFERING A SOLUTION[S]

Housekeeping

We are in the homestretch; hang in there, folks!

What is a Proposal?

A technical/ business proposal is a special type of report which addresses a problem or a need. In fact, oftentimes if needs are not addressed, they become even greater problems that require resolutions.

Types of Proposals aka Classification

Proposals can be **internal** or **external**, **short** of **long**, and must be adapted to various types of audiences. Since they are analytical, they require a number of parts, beginning with the demonstration. The demonstration includes a background of the problem, the purpose, the methodology and scope.

Your Proposal will be…

Internal. In other words, you will need to identify a University of Akron problem or issue and propose a solution. I will even go as far as to say UA adjacent… meaning a City of Akron problem or issue that can affect our school directly or indirectly.

Once you have given background

Once it is clear that a problem or need exists, the writer must offer solution(s) to the problem/need that are workable, feasible, and affordable. Thus, the heart of the proposal is comprised of such factors as timetables, costs, resources, and any other specific factors that must be considered for the proposal to be accepted. Essentially, the advantages of adopting the proposal must outweigh the disadvantages in order for it to be accepted.

The end result?

Companies/Institutions improve businesses and grow businesses on proposals, so whether short or long, they are written in all areas of a company.

In your textbook, there is an example of a formal proposal. It is the same sample in Lesson 5, which can easily be adapted for any type of report, short (1-3 pages), mid-length (4-6 pages), or long (7+pages--the most formal type). You also completed a plan for your informational report, so do follow the same format.

Formatting Concerns

This time, I want you to get out of your comfort zone a bit and start using more of the Modified APA formatting approach. This means not using Memo as your default setting so-to-speak. With that being said, I will be expecting the following:

1. APA title page
2. Headings and Subheadings
3. References page for sources
4. Visuals within the text, no appendices.

Suggested Readings

Read Chapter 16: Formal reports

Review Chapter 17: Proposals

Review Chapter 7: Visuals

You will find samples of a title page and proposal in this announcement

Some additional pointers…

Make a list of the Stakeholders. These are people who have something to lose or gain based on the problem or issue. They are often with you or against you. At the very least, they have influence and insight.

Speaking of those who are not with you…

There will be opposing views. Count on it!

This refers to questions, comments, and/or concerns from the other side.

One of the most diplomatic ways to address the aforementioned opposing views is to have a section of Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ’s) This is a proactive way to respond before your audience even has a chance to state them. Talk about diffusing a situation.

Always respect the other side…

Never ignore their questions, comments, or concerns.

Never speak poorly about the other side.

Choose your sources wisely…

* facts and figures
* support for your claims
* background
* opposing views

Come to terms early…

…with what you don’t know.

In other words, figure out what you don’t know/need to know for this proposal.

Use Cause and Effect to your advantage…

This is a great mode/genre to explain what has happened. Consider action/reaction or choice/consequences.

It can also be used to predict or forecast what will happen.

Watch out for faulty causation. In other words prove and explain the link between cause and effect.

Proposals should have a confident, not a cocky tone.

You want to sound prepared, like you are sure of yourself, not full of yourself.